

*Papyrus stems are not
round, but triangular.*

Papyrus

Some plants are so important, they helped to shape history. One is papyrus (puh-pie-rus). This is a type of grass-like plant called a sedge, with a top like a pom-pom. It loves to have its roots wet so it grows in marshes and at the edges of rivers. Here, it shoots up to be as tall as an elephant.

Around 5,000 years ago, the Ancient Egyptians worked out how to use the strong fibres from papyrus stalks to make sails for their boats, as well as baskets, rope, and sandals.

Most useful of all, they turned the fibres into a thick type of paper, also called papyrus. The Egyptians used it to record important information, such as medical knowledge and mathematics.